What Mom Owns and Whose Name Is on It

A worksheet to fill in before you ask what she can keep.

“The house is in both their names, I think” is a guess. The names printed on the deed are something you can copy down, and a copied-down fact is what a professional can work from.

Fill this in with the papers in front of you where you can, and copy what they say. Where you haven't seen the paper, write “not sure” and leave it. A plain description of each thing is enough. This page doesn't need amounts or account numbers.

The house

The name or names on the deed, copied as they are printed. Who lives there now. Where the deed is kept.

FOR EXAMPLE Deed is in the file cabinet at the house: Mom's and Dad's names, both. Dad lives there. Nobody has looked at it since they bought the place.

Bank, savings and retirement accounts

One line for each: what kind of account, where it is held, and the name or names printed on the statement. For a retirement account, the named beneficiary if you know it.

FOR EXAMPLE Checking at the credit union: statement shows both names. Savings: Mom's name only, I think. Haven't seen a statement. Mom's retirement account from the school district: beneficiary not sure.

Insurance and other things of value

Insurance policies and who is named on each. A car, personal property worth noting, anything held in a trust, anything owned with someone other than Dad.

FOR EXAMPLE Life insurance policy on Mom: Dad thinks he's the one named. The car is in Dad's name. A trust was mentioned years ago. Nobody has the papers.

What we've been told, and by whom

Each thing you've heard about what Mom can keep, with who said it, when, and whether they had seen your papers. Don't judge whether it's right.

FOR EXAMPLE A neighbor told us what happened with her mother's house. Different state, different family. To confirm. Nobody who has seen our papers has said anything yet.

What we're assuming, and our questions for a professional

The things you believe but nobody who knows Mom's situation has told you, each turned into a question. Beside each, who you think it goes to.

FOR EXAMPLE Each of us has been assuming something different about the house, and none of it came from anyone who has seen the deed. Question: what happens to the house? For your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. Not sure which.

Who filled this in, and on what date

What this shows you

Three things: what there is, whose name is on it as far as the papers show, and where the blanks are. It doesn't show what Mom can keep. There is no column here for how Medicaid treats anything, on purpose: that depends on your state's rules and on Mom's and Dad's situation, and it is a professional's to say. Nothing on this page adds up to a result, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what the papers say instead of what everyone remembers, with the blanks left showing. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring, with this worksheet, to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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